

BITS PILANI, DUBAI CAMPUS

Dubai International Academic City, U.A.E.

Semester I 2022-23

Mid-Sem (CLOSED BOOK)

Course No: HSS F211

Course Title: Modern Political Concepts

Date: October 24, 2022 Time: 90 mins Maximum Marks: 30 Weightage: 30

Name.....

ID No.

Please circle the most appropriate answer. Each Question carries 2 marks.

Answers have been highlighted with Yellow colours

Q 1.) Which one of the following forms of the Capitalism lays emphasis on importance of Consumerism and Consumer choices

- a) Crony Capitalism
- b) Advanced Capitalism
- c) Free Market Capitalism
- d) Unrestrained Capitalism

(Hints: see the Capitalism PPT, especially the Advanced Capitalism slide)

Q 2) Which of the following political thinker/philosopher said that the presence of many buyers and many sellers competing with one another in the marketplace would weed out wasteful resource allocations

- a) F. Hayek
- b) J.M. Keynes
- c) Adam Smith
- d) None of the above

(Hints: see the Capitalism PPT, especially Adam Smith)

Q3 Which of the following Philosophers made the below statement

“From each according to his ability, to each according to his need.”

- a) F. Hayek

- b) Karl Marx
- c) Adam Smith
- d) J.M.Keynes

(Hints: see the Socialism PPT, especially key ideology/key terms part)

Q4) Among your friends one of the Friends borrows money to buy things and delays the repayment. His tendencies are like

- a) Marxist
- b) Socialist
- c) Keynesian
- d) Hayekist

(Hints: see the Capitalism PPT, especially the videos on the last slide)

Q 5. Revolution can be brought not by proletariat but Students, ethnic minorities women and workers. Who among the following said this:

- a) Karl Marx
- b) J. M. Keynes
- c) Eduard Bernstein
- d) Herbert Marcuse

(Hints: see the Socialism PPT, especially key thinkers of Socialism)

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Course No: HSS F211

Course Title: Modern Political Concepts

Date: 01 Nov 2022

Time: 90 mins

Maximum Marks: 30

Weightage: 30

Instructions:

- 1) Please read the questions properly. Some of the Questions are divided into sub-sections. Answer each section.
- 2) The questions have been set to assess your attentiveness during the classes. Please avoid a common-sense approach while answering your questions.
- 3) Do not use the PPT template. Answer your questions in the essay format.
- 4) Write each answer in minimum 300 words. You can write your answers in more than 300 words as well if you are unable to sum up the answer in those many words. However, do not write more than the required word limit just to fill the space.

Answer key

1) What is Feminism? How do the two schools (Liberal Feminism and Socialist Feminism) within Feminism differ from each other on “women empowerment.”? What approach do they take to achieve gender equality? Please explain. **(5 marks)**

Q2) Identify the key features of Socialism. Explain at least five key features of Socialism in your words. **(5 marks)**

Q3) What is the central thesis of Keynes? Why do the states/government take Keynes’s prescription to revive demand even though they are aware that the boom generated through the intervention will lead to a bust sooner or later? Explain. **(5 marks)**

Q4) Who made the following statement? What does he want to convey? Please deconstruct the statement and explain in your words. **(5 marks)**

“Private capital tends to become concentrated in few hands, partly because of competition among the capitalists, and partly because technological development and the increasing division of labor encourage the formation of larger units of production at the expense of smaller ones. The result of these developments is an oligarchy of private capital the enormous power of which cannot be effectively checked even by a democratically organized political society.”

Ans: The statement was made by Albert Einstein in his article “Why Socialism”. The student can explain the content from the socialist perspective in their own words and as explained by the instructor in the class.

Q5) “The price of the bean, of the fish, of the flour, of the rent, of the shoes, and of the medicine,” all depend on the political decisions. Who made this statement? Does the price depend on political decisions? If so, explain with at least three examples. If no, then back your arguments with three examples to falsify the statement. **(5 marks)**

You can give other examples and developments that has taken place after we concluded the class. However, it should be based on governmnets/political decisions impacting the price.

Q 6) which political philosophy/concept believes in the idea of “night watchmen state”? What do they mean when they say that the state should be like “night watchmen.” Please elaborate. **(5 marks)**

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Semester I 2022-23

Compre Exam (Closed BOOK)

Course No: HSS F211

Course Title: Modern Political Concepts

Date: January 3, 2023 Time: 10 mins Maximum Marks: 10 Weightage: 10

Part I

Name-----

Q 1) All the great personalities have drawn inspiration from philosophers, novelists, and political thinkers and their ideas. Mahatma Gandhi was also inspired by such personalities and their key ideas. Gandhi drew ideas of non-violence from and imbibed them into his political philosophy.

- a) John Ruskin
- b) Gopal Krishna Gokhale
- c) Leo Tolstoy
- d) Plato

Q2) Below is the list of books and key ideas presented in the book. Please identify the correct match.

- | | |
|---|---|
| A) The Theory of Moral Sentiment | 1. A nation is a mental image |
| B) Das Capital | 2. Adverse Impact of Capitalism on Society |
| C) Imagined Community | 3. An invisible hand regulates markets |
| D) A vindication of the Rights of women | 4. Hunting community was an Egalitarian society |
| | 5. Personhood |

- a) A-3, B-1, C-5, D-4 b) A-3, B-2, C-1, D-5 c) A-2, B-3, C-4, D-5 d) A-1, B-4, C-3, D-5

Q3) Present Society is defined as “Society 5.0”. Identify Society 3.0 from the list below

- a) Agrarian society b) Industrial Society c) Information age society d) None of these

Q4) Who made the following statement?

Technology alone is not enough. It's technology married with liberal arts, married with humanities, that yields the results that make our hearts sing.

- a) Albert Einstein b) Rabindranath Tagore c) Steve Jobs d) Karl Marx

Q 5) Please correctly match with the Political Concepts and the idea that emerged from the Political concept

- | | |
|---------------|----------------------|
| A. Anarchism | 1. Welfare State |
| B. Socialism | 2. Toleration |
| C. Marxism | 3. Mutual aid |
| D. Liberalism | 4. Classless Society |
| | 5. Strong State |

- a) A-3, B-2, C-5, D-1 b) A-3, B-1, C-5, D-2 **c) A-3, B-1, C-4, D-2** d) A-4, B-2, C-1, D-3

Q6. Which of the following Philosophers/ leaders/ Political Scientists described the nation as a “Cultural Concept”

- a) Johann Herder b) Benedict Anderson c) Rousseau d) Adolf Hitler

Q7) In the conference on economic recession various speakers participate in Panel discussion. A person wearing “Red hat” argues that government should give stimulus to bring the economy out of recession. Another person wearing a “White hat” is of the view that the stimulus to big business to increase the supply side will not suffice, the government should give incentives by giving cash to low-income families to increase demand. The third person wearing “Black hat” argues that the government should not give stimulus as it is likely to go to waste.

Based on the above discussion identify the ideological inclination of each speaker from the given options below

(Anarchist, Socialist, Feminist, Keynesian, Hayekist, Nationalist)

Red hat..... Keynesian White hat..... Socialist Black hat..... Hayekist

Q8) Revolution can be brought not by the proletariat but Students, ethnic minorities women, and workers. Who among the following made this statement:

- a) Karl Marx b) J. M. Keynes c) Eduard Bernstein d) Herbert Marcuse

Q9) Which of the following form of Nationalism believes in social cohesion and public order rooted in patriotism?

- a) Conservative nationalism, b) Liberal Nationalism c) Socialist Nationalism d) None of these

Q10) Which of the following philosopher suggested that human labour was source of economic value

- a) Adam Smith b) Keynes c) Karl Marx d) Hayek

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Semester I 2022-23

Compre Exam (Closed BOOK)

Course No: HSS F211

Course Title: Modern Political Concepts

Date: January 3, 2023 Time: 3hrs Maximum Marks: 30 Weightage: 30

Part II

Answer Key

Q1) Please write short notes on the following concepts in not less than 100 words each. Please give real-life examples wherever possible (05 marks)

- a) Misogyny b) Social Contract c) Libertarian d) Surplus Value e) glass ceiling

Ans: For all the above concepts write short note and give examples. Please use info from the PPTs and class elaboration/discussion

Q2) What is Nationalism? Identify the kinds of nationalism and explain the key concept of each nationalism (5 marks)

Ans: Define the Concept of Nationalism (see Nationalism PPT)

Explain its kinds a) Liberal Nationalism, b) Conservative Nationalism c) Expansionist Nationalism and d) Colonial and Anti-colonial Nationalism and elaborate what each of them stand for.

Q3) State has been a key theme of most of the political concepts that you have studied. Please explain how each concept envisions the state and argues about the State. **(10 marks)**

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(hint: note down all the concepts and explain how they view the State)

Part III

Q4) Please read the text below and sum up the arguments (conveying all points) in three sentences. Your sentences could be long with commas, punctuations but should not exceed three sentences limit. **(5 marks)**

A dubious economic theory has continued for so long perhaps because of its nicely sounding name of “trickle-down economics.” The theory claims that benefits for the wealthy and big businesses will trickle down to the middle and lower classes.

Though many economists have rejected it as a misguided theory, trickle-down economics has appeared, disappeared and then reappeared again and again like a ghost.

In Japan, this theory was referred to as part of a debate on “Abenomics” economic policies advocated by then Prime Minister Shinzo Abe.

Just as we were about to write off the policy as gone for good, we saw its latest revival in the ill-fated massive tax cut package put forth by former British Prime Minister Liz Truss.

Predictably, the proposal provoked fierce public backlash and was roundly criticized as an ill-conceived policy favoring the rich. With the proposal triggering serious turmoil in the financial markets, Truss became the country’s shortest-serving prime minister.

The theory, which has a long history, reached its apex of glory in the 1980s, when the British administration of Margaret Thatcher pushed an economic policy agenda based on new liberalism and designed to achieve “small government.”

While I was studying economics at a university in Britain at that time, I was taught that the thinking behind Thatcher’s economic policy was known as the “horse-and-sparrow” theory.

The instructor said the metaphor went: If a horse is fed enough oats, some would pass through to the road in the form of excrement for the sparrows.

When the term “trickle-down economics” gained currency, I suspected only that lecturer used such a vulgar metaphor and searched through various economic literature. I found that reputed economist John Kenneth Galbraith had used the “horse-and-sparrow” metaphor in describing the theory as heartless to the poor, saying it “has always been greeted with mild derision.”

During her last Question Time debate between party leaders in Parliament before leaving office, an opposition politician criticized Thatcher’s economic policy by pointing out the gap between the richest and the poorest in Britain had “widened substantially.”

She retorted by saying, “he (the opposition politician) would rather have the poor poorer, provided that the rich were less rich.” She remained committed to her belief that benefits to the rich were indirectly the succor of the poor.

The trickle-down theory has long stirred people's imaginations, spawning a raft of colorful metaphors, such as wine overflowing from glasses, water cascading from a fountain and, of course "the horse and sparrow," but it seems the time has come to ring the death knell for it.

Q5) Please read the text below. A) briefly capture the argument and b) critique and counter argument made by the author of the text. **(5 marks)**

The author Nathan J Robinson debunks the ongoing arguments/debate that "capitalists are not personally greedy" in this essay.

Some leftists say that capitalists are not personally greedy and act as they do because the system forces them to. But that's wrong. Capitalist greed is indeed a choice.

- [Nathan J. Robinson](#)

If you are [new to](#) socialist theory, you might assume that socialists think capitalists are greedy—that owners and bosses are selfish and immoral and trying to get as rich as possible because of their personal acquisitiveness. But, especially among Marxist socialists, a lot of thinkers on the left actually reject this way of talking. For instance, in Vivek Chibber's forthcoming book [Confronting Capitalism: How the World Works and How To Change It](#), a useful plain-language primer on socialist economic theory, Chibber writes that "capitalists aren't motivated by greed but by market pressures." He elaborates:

Capitalists don't cause harm to their employees out of malice or greed. Their motivation comes from the brute reality of market competition. If a capitalist doesn't produce at the lowest price, he knows that he will lose customers, and if that continues, his firm will start bleeding money. So he has to keep his selling price as low as possible. But if he's going to lower his selling price, he also has to lower his costs, or he won't make any money. Hence, he tries to pay out as little as possible for his inputs—the machines and raw material that he buys, and the wages he's paying to his workers. So every capitalist constantly tries to get the most out of every dollar he spends, including from his workers. This is how firms survive in the market. It has nothing to do with greed.

Ben Burgis, in Jacobin, [says along the same lines](#):

Crucially, the capitalist drive to accumulate money isn't primarily about individual capitalists being bad, greedy people, but rather the relentless pressures of the system itself. A capitalist who doesn't ruthlessly pursue profits will be outcompeted by those who do.

This fits with the story that many capitalists tell themselves, which is that they are not *in it for themselves*. If your boss cuts your pay, you will be given an explanation to do with *market forces*. [No capitalist ever confessed](#) that they just want to earn as much money as possible because they like money.

Now, the story told about market forces putting pressure on capitalists to cut costs is true, and it explains why exploitation may not be *purely* the result of employers' selfishness. But the

Marxist argument is wrong, because it concludes from this that capitalists are not motivated by greed and selfishness, even though this is precisely why capitalists go beyond “surviving” in the marketplace and actually become *rich*.

One reason I can tell there is no necessity beyond selfishness to pursue gain is that I have started and run a “business” myself that does not pursue gain, and I know that it was a *choice* for me not to try to maximize my gains. *Current Affairs* is subject to certain market pressures (we have to keep our magazine priced low enough to where people will buy it), and the [lack of money](#) in media means that salaries at *Current Affairs* aren’t very high. But nothing compels us to pursue *profit*, that is to make money *above* what it takes to cover our costs. If we want to expand the business, we will need to make money. If we were incorporated as a for-profit enterprise that needed to “maximize shareholder value,” we would need to make as much money as possible. But these are *choices*, not imperatives imposed upon us by the economic system. I know that it is not necessary to maximize profit in order for a “firm to survive in the market” because I have spent six years helping a firm survive in the market without pursuing any such imperative.

Chibber and Burgis explain why a capitalist who does seek to maximize profits will need to exploit people, and why even a business that is not operated for profit may find itself having to cut costs ruthlessly in order to survive in a competitive market. But market forces do *not* constitute an explanation for why a capitalist would ever need to maximize *their* own profits in the first place. The desire to maximize one’s return is a function of greed.

Capitalists *are* greedy, and very obviously so. In fact, elsewhere in the book, Chibber gives us evidence that capitalists are greedy. Explaining how a capitalist who invests money is seeking to make more money, Chibber writes that “while it is important for him to recoup his original investment, of course this isn’t all he needs. For one thing, he wouldn’t have made any money for himself.” If not for the additional increment the capitalist makes over and above what is put in originally, “his entire effort becomes a kind of philanthropic endeavor, in which he pays out to others, but takes nothing home for himself. ... [A]s everyone knows, it is the pursuit of profit that shapes the entire organization of production in capitalism.”

But what prevents the capitalist from operating philanthropically, and taking nothing for themselves? Or taking home only the same amount as the lowest-paid worker? Why does the capitalist need to “take something home” over and above the amount needed to subsist? It’s perfectly possible to start a business and operate it in the interests of the community without using it to make a fortune. The capitalist chooses to try to make money, and it’s that choice that is accurately described as acquisitiveness, or greed, because nothing in the economic system mandates it. Jeff Bezos does not need to be a billionaire. He didn’t need to take any ownership of Amazon himself. He exploits people for his own benefit because he has an insatiable greed and lust for power, not because facts about the economy compel him to own the company.

When we are asking whether capitalists act as they do out of *greed* or if they are compelled by some kind of systemic force, one way to test the proposition is to think about what would happen if we substituted an altruist in the capitalist’s role. We can see that certain things would not change. If you made the CEO of a company an altruist, but the CEO was under a legal mandate to maximize shareholder value, then if they exploited their workers less the board of directors might replace them. The altruistic CEO alone may have few options to improve the company. But the *owner* of a company, the person who puts up the capital, can make a huge difference depending on whether they are pursuing gain or the public good. Pursuing gain means

that workers have to be *more* exploited than market pressures alone require so that a sum of profit can go to the owner. If public good is the goal, no such sum need be generated. Nor does the owner need to relentlessly expand the business in order to pursue larger profits. The business can stay the same size, if doing so serves the public good.

Since it is obviously wrong to say that capitalists aren't greedy, why would socialists make this argument? One reason is that Marxism, often presented as a kind of "[scientific socialism](#)," developed as a way of trying to understand the economy as a machine that operated according to certain principles. Engels, in [discussing](#) the utopian socialists, said that socialists prior to Marx had seen socialism as a grand moral idea, an expression of "absolute truth, reason, and justice" that "has only to be discovered to conquer all the world by virtue of its own power." Indeed, Robert Owen, the wealthy textile manufacturer who founded early socialist communities, said on his deathbed that he "gave important truths to the world, and it was only for want of understanding that they were disregarded." Marx and Engels realized that simply exposing that capitalism was immoral and that socialism would be better was not enough. One needed to understand the mechanisms of capitalism in order to figure out how to replace it. "Moralism" became a dirty word among many socialists, because morality was perceived to be mostly irrelevant. The Marxist socialist is not a religious teacher but an engineer who takes apart the machine, sees how it works, and tries to rebuild it to work along different lines.

To this day, many socialists also do not see capitalists as being particularly *human*, and so they are inclined to explain them as rational-maximizing robots. To treat the capitalist as selfish is to treat them as a person who could do better, rather than a faceless money-maximizing automaton, which is what they often appear as from the worker's perspective.

It makes quite a bit of sense, then, that socialists wouldn't want to humanize capitalists by making them seem as if they are people just like ourselves. But ironically, in developing a theory that capitalists cannot do otherwise, they let capitalists off the hook. They gave up the argument that being rich is immoral, even though [it obviously is](#). This socialist argument allows people like [Elon Musk](#) to say that they aren't greedy even as they violate every norm of human ethics to accrue as much for themselves as possible, without anything in the economy forcing them to do so.

Importantly, the fact that capitalists are selfish, and that their selfishness drives a great deal of their exploitative behavior, does *not* mean that we simply need to persuade the world's owners to be nicer or to voluntarily shed their possessions and turn their companies over to the community or the workers. It could simultaneously be true that personal greed plays a major role in the pursuit of profit and that attempts to talk greedy people out of being greedy are doomed to fail. One of the fears that some Marxists have, I suspect, is that when we begin to talk in *moral* terms, we start to think of political action in terms of *making people better*, rather than seizing power. But the moral and the militant need not be considered mutually exclusive. We can be cynical about the likelihood of capitalists' becoming better through moral exhortation alone and also recognize that, for the most part, it is not the "market" but their own pathological and sociopathic pursuit of their self-interest that compels them to act as they do.

Sometimes something that is very obviously untrue is believed because everyone has an interest in believing it, even if those interests vary or are opposed. So, for instance, both the government and an anti-government terrorist group might have an interest in exaggerating the strength of the terrorist group. Similarly, both socialists and capitalists have good reasons to say that capitalists aren't "selfish" but it is "the system" that compels them to act as they do. So an argument that makes little sense and is obviously at odds with reality (where rich people could

easily choose not to be rich, and capitalists make profits by choice) persists because it is convenient for both the system's proponents and its critics to believe it. But the fact that a falsehood is useful does not justify believing it.

Some of capitalism's defenders do *not* make the argument that capitalists aren't greedy (though usually they prefer the term "self-interest," which sounds much less objectionable). Milton Friedman [replied](#) to the question of whether capitalism was built on greed by insisting that Russia and China run on greed as well. But this is not a justification, either. We must reject the idea coming from many wealthy people that, as Jag Bhalla [puts it](#), "unbridled greed is just simple human nature." (Bhalla says we have accepted a "greedocracy.") We ought to acknowledge the simple fact that those who try to get more than they need to live a life of basic comfort, with [luxuries of the kind that everyone deserves](#), have accumulated their luxuries *because* they have deprived others along the way. This has been done by choice. Everyone could have had plenty, because there is plenty to go around, but decisions are made every day that prevent this outcome. Nobody makes the capitalist maximize profits, or pay their workers less than they pay themselves, and "the market made me do it" is an excuse that should make socialists highly dubious. And while it is the case that persuading capitalists to shed their wealth and join the proletariat is not an intelligent revolutionary strategy, it is crucial for socialists to understand that human beings are not mere billiard balls whose moral choices are dictated by the systems we are in. We have agency, and that agency confers responsibility. There are no excuses for enriching one's self and exploiting others.